

Balance Problems (Vestibular Disease) in Dogs

The **vestibular system** — parts of the inner ear and brain — tells your dog which way is up. When it is disrupted, the effects can be frightening to watch, but many dogs recover well.

Signs

- **Head tilt**, usually toward the affected side
- Stumbling, falling or leaning to one side; walking in circles
- **Abnormal eye movements** — darting side to side or in circles (nystagmus)
- **Nausea and vomiting** (like motion sickness)
- Reluctance to move; confusion or disorientation

Types

1. Peripheral (inner ear) — usually less serious

- **"Old dog vestibular disease"** — common in older dogs, no cause found; usually much better in **2–3 weeks**
- Middle or inner ear infections
- Head injury
- Congenital (present from birth)

2. Central (brain) — usually more serious

- Brain inflammation (infection or immune-mediated)
- Brain tumors
- Stroke

Diagnosis

Physical and **neurological exam**, ear exam, blood tests, and imaging (**MRI or CT**) when a brain or middle-ear

cause is suspected.

Treatment

Depends on the cause:

- Old dog vestibular disease: supportive care and anti-nausea medication
- Ear infections: antibiotics (sometimes long courses)
- Brain disease: treatment specific to the cause

Caring for your dog at home

- Clear paths; block stairs and pools; cover slippery floors with rugs
- Use a **harness** or towel sling to help with walking
- Put food and water within easy reach; hand-feed if needed
- A comfortable bed in a quiet spot
- Give medications exactly as directed
- Most dogs adapt quickly, even if a **mild head tilt remains**

Call us right away if

- Signs **worsen quickly**
- Your dog **cannot stand or walk**
- **Seizures** or collapse
- Not eating or drinking for **more than 24 hours**

Outlook

Most dogs with peripheral (inner-ear) disease improve greatly within **2–3 weeks**. The outlook for brain-related disease depends on the underlying cause.